

Focus on Culture: American Videogame Landscapes (552.311, 22W)

Seminar Paper

US American myths representation in Bioshock Infinite's Landscape

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September 30, 2023

Word count: 2450

This paper demonstrates how the landscape of *Bioshock Infinite* (hereafter *Infinite*) (Irrational Games 2013) epitomises the US-American myth. The landscape of Columbia, the city of *Infinite*, is multifaceted and unstable, which are two qualities of the political discourses on the theme of a “City upon a Hill”, a term coined by John Winthrop in 1630 that has been reused numerous times in the more recent U.S. American public political discourse (see Squiers 2018, 62). The game has an achronological approach to the US American history which reinforces its mythological space. The themes of nostalgia, travel, and deception, inherent to the US American myth, are analysed in the last part. This paper shows how Columbia as an unstable landscape, takes its inspiration from multiple periods and deals with the philosophical and affective aspects of the myth.

In this paper, *Infinite* is understood through the lens of “Videogame as spatial stories” as James Newman words it (2004, 113). To understand this concept, we need to define the concepts of space, place, and landscape.

Newman defines spaces in the relationship they have with the players. Spaces can be against the players, manipulated by them, and restrictive for them (Newman 2004). I consider the landscape constituted by “places” and “spaces” according to Fuller’s and Jenkins’s definition: “Places exist only in the abstract, as potential sites for narrative action, as locations that have not yet been colonized. Places constitute a ‘stability’ which must be disrupted in order for stories to unfold . . . Spaces, on the other hand, are places that have been acted upon, explored, colonized. Spaces become the locations of narrative events.” (Fuller and Jenkins 1995, 66)

Infinite’s space can be categorised using Newman’s Spatial Typology (2004, 115). The player character is placed against his environment, he is “in the world but not necessarily of it”. Even though the game’s narrative implies major modifications of the landscape (for instance multidimensional travels), the players’ agency in these modifications is minor. However, during combat phases the player can create different objects (covers, water poodles, ammunitions) that “contribute (,) to the stated game objective” (Newman 2004, 117) and thus makes it temporarily a dynamic space.

Infinite is self-reflexive about the player’s experience within the game’s space. In video games, players are forced to inhabit the landscapes and navigate through them. At the entrance of Columbia, when the player character Booker says “I only want to get through”, he is immediately stopped by the priest he is talking to and gets his head submerged under water for a baptism-like ceremony. In the same way, the video game players can not be passive in front of their screen and have to embody their avatar, Booker is explicitly told that he will have to inhabit the city of Columbia.

Columbia is also designed analogically to what the video game space is according to Nitsche (2008), Newman (2004) and Boym (2001). Virtual space has multiple times been defined and compared to sacred space (Nitsche 2008, 191-2), and embodies its paradox as it “is spatial but not a place” (Nitsche 2008, 191), in the sense that it has spatial qualities (explorable, architectural etc.) but is not influenced by the real world constraints except for “logic, software, and hardware development” (ibid.). This is also the case of Columbia, a place heavily dependent on technology and defying “geographical, zoological, and most physical dependencies”(ibid.). The players’ experience of a videogame space has also been defined in parallel to US American history: “the centrality of space in the formation of the videogaming experience is seen to bear arresting similarities to the New World travel narratives of sixteenth- and seventeenth-century voyagers and explorer” (Newman 2004, 113). Lastly, virtual spaces are defined as sub-urban spaces that enable players to develop a different sense of time and space (Boym 2001, 81). These new spaces renew the experience of lost freedom of navigation and exploration (Newman 2004, 112-113) due to massive urbanisation. This is also the case of Columbia, which has virtually left the Earth to create its spatiality and temporality during the industrialisation of the late 19th century.

Understanding *Infinite*’s landscape in terms of “arena” and “labyrinth” (Nitsche 2008, Sanchez Garcia 2020) parallels a violent as well as a non-violent conquest of space. During the gameplay, the landscape of Columbia switches fluidly from labyrinth to arena in the sense that the players alternate between exploration phases, in which the city is a labyrinth to explore, and combat phases where they have to master the arena space to win the fight. This dynamic makes the players experience their navigation both as “strangers” and as a citizen who knows how to navigate in the city (Sanchez Garcia 2020, 13). The game starts in its labyrinth form as the players can only explore their surroundings in a limited space. The landscape of *Infinite* is designed so the players experience both a violent and a peaceful conquest of space through exploration and fighting in the labyrinthic city.

On a larger scale, *Infinite* always pushes forward the transformation of places into spaces (see Fuller and Jenkins 1995, 66). This phenomenon starts at the very beginning with the postcard of Columbia that will later be explored by the players, and then in the presentation of Columbia’s landscape, letting the city’s different places and times appear (Figure 1).

Figure 1: Different representations of Columbia with the monument tower in the first ten minutes of gameplay, screenshots from BioShock Infinite Full Walkthrough Gameplay - No Commentary (PC Longplay)



a)Postal card



b)First view of Columbia



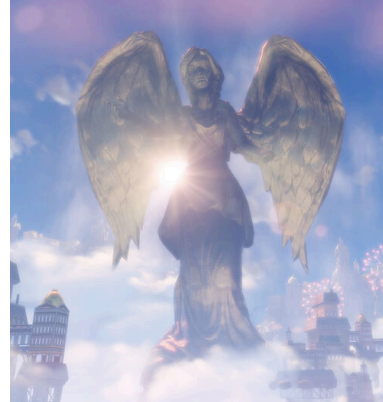
c) Columbia used as a weapon

The landscape of *Infinite* can also be understood with the concepts of restorative and reflective nostalgia (Boym 2001). In terms of buildings, “[r]estorative nostalgia manifests itself in total reconstruction of monuments of the past, while reflective nostalgia lingers on ruins” (Boym 2001, 41). The Monument Tower (Figure 2a), the main landmark of Columbia, a distorted reproduction of the Statue of the Republic (Figure 2b) from the Columbian World Exposition, and the ruins (Figure 2c), lying in the dimension where the revolution happened, illustrate this.

Figure 2: *Restorative and reflective nostalgia in the landscape.*



a) Statue of the Republic



b) Monument Tower



b) Ruins of the city

Columbia fits the definition of Retrotopia (Bauman 2017) as it exhibits the two defining properties which come from the double negations to Thomas More's Utopia. Zygmunt Bauman defines retrotopias as “visions located in the lost/stolen/abandoned but undead past, instead of being tied to the not-yet-unborn and so inexistent future” (2017, 5). The first negation is the subjectification of the Utopia, and Columbia is a place conceived and led by a single person. The second negation is a sclerosis of the Utopia. It no longer exists by imagining a hopeful future but by reimagining a past, creating myths, but still tying it to a possible future. The utopia has become a fixed point from which any change or indeed progress is impossible.

One eloquent musical example happens during the exploration of the fair, where the players can encounter a barbershop quartet singing “God Only Knows” (Figure 3) originally written by The Beach Boys. This reveals a reinterpretation of the past including the international success of the US American rock music of the sixties in the culture at the turn of the century. More evidently, the architecture plays a role in its achronological landscape with inspiration from both Federal-Style architecture (Figure 4a) and Georgy Krutikov’s flying city (Figure 4b) (Manuel 2020, 16).

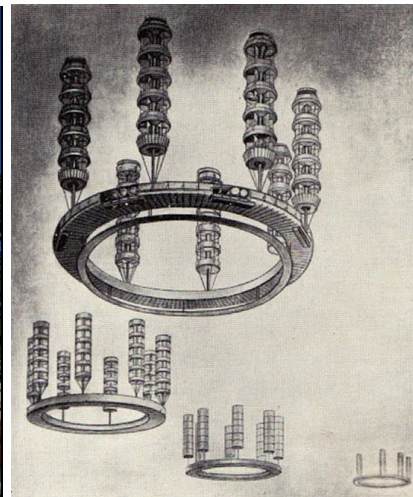
Figure 3: *The Barbershop Quartet*



Figure 4: a) *Photo of the University of Virginia*



b) *Krutikov's drawing of his flying city*



The city can be considered as a reflection of the landscape it was built in (Nitsche 2008,162), and in the case of Columbia it is both the World Columbian Exposition, a world-scaled advertising event for the US,

and the sky, which is an empty (unstable if we take the clouds in account) landscape. The game is set in an alternative world in which the floating city of Columbia was presented during the World's Columbian Exposition in 1893 and then took its independence. In the real world, it is also during this exposition that the automobile and the picture postcard were presented (Gross 2005). *Infinite* reflects it very well, by first presenting Columbia's landscape through a postcard. On another level, the postcard is in itself a combination of advertising and money-making (Gross 2005, 82). This is seen in the first part of the game's landscape welcoming pilgrims with beautiful buildings and shops. The car and its development with Ford's assembly line shaped most of Columbia's economic model and the Fink's factory.

Instability also characterises the floating city of Columbia, arguably because it is based on US American myths. These myths consist of heroic figures like the founding fathers, presidents, and revolutionaries or concepts like the "shining city upon a hill". In *Infinite*, all those symbols are multifaceted and exist in several parallel dimensions that the players explore. "They are myths not in the sense of being false, but in that their meaning is never fixed" (Haselby 2015, 21).

The term "city upon a hill" reflects the instability of the American myth and exceptionalism. The *Arbella* sermon in which John Winthrop speaks of New England as a "city upon a hill" was never published in his lifetime (Heimert 1985, 81). This expression has been reinterpreted differently throughout US history. Through the lens of nostalgia, we can interpret that the Puritans, whose conception of Christianity is close to Comstock's, use this term (Holub 2013, 10) in a restorative nostalgia manner (see Boym 2001, 41-43). On the other hand, Heimert understands it more as reflective nostalgia (see Boym 2001, 49), where "Winthrop envisions an American future in which a Pauline growth in grace might be possible" (ibid., 81). This expression stuck throughout the history of the US: "Numerous U.S. politicians of both major parties have utilised Winthrop's phrase to market their agenda of American exceptionalism" (Holub 2013, 10). Although the term has a variety of meanings and uses, Holub (2013) argues that the term unifies the American exceptionalism discourse around the "aggressive foreign policy" (Spanos 2003, 30).

Instability implies transformation and in the case of *Infinite*, deception. Every evolution of the landscape goes for the worst. This comes with an increase of displayed brutal violence throughout the game and the travels between the multiple dimensions.

This deception is part of the transformation that the main plot and the landscape impose on the player. During the playthrough, the players discover the darker places of Columbia but also transformations in the landscape. The placards are more racist and the exploitation of the labourers is made clearer. It is also

common for heroic figures to become enemies throughout the game. For example, the revolutionary group that seems to be the player character's allies and the solution to overthrow the prophet leader Comstock becomes a horde of enemies to fight when travelling to a parallel dimension of Columbia where the city gets destroyed. Figures like George Washington are also present in the game as war machines that the player must destroy. By unfolding the story, the players also discover the darker side of the protagonist, who also could be a hero at first glance, and realise that took part in the Wounded Knee Massacre. Furthermore, the very end of the game reveals that Booker and Comstock are the same person but from different dimensions. The myths that are used during the game are always shown in different ways so the players are always deceived by them.

The player's journey to Columbia can be compared to the deceiving journeys of the French intellectuals of the late 18th century as analysed by Lacorne (2001). Enlightenment philosophers like Voltaire found in the US citizens an existing utopia for their thoughts. A place where men and women have the same rights, where rich and poor live together peacefully. However, their first deception was the "mighty dollar" ideology that was present everywhere. In the same way, the players first learn about Columbia with a postcard of a brilliant city, then about its religion and lastly about the omnipresence of the industrialist Fink.

The separation of Columbia from the real world can find its parallel in the oppression of the Quakers in the Massachusetts Bay Colony. It could be interpreted as "What if the Bay Colony did not have Mother England?". The tolerance came from the England crown which had a bigger political interest in keeping the calm in his kingdom (Wills 2007, 21). This history of tolerance in the USA is also present in the history of its Religion. The American Bible Society did accept a lot of denominations to grow bigger and get enough influence and financial power. It was only then that some denominations started to be designated as sects to decide which religious current was tolerated or not (Haselby 2015, 236). In this sense, it is clear that *Infinite* does not make a criticism of Christian Religion in itself. Comstock can be seen as a sect leader, and in American history they were quickly identified as such and put apart. "If a religious group does not respect the sanctity of the civil law, they remove themselves from the protections of civil religion, becoming instead "sectarian" (Haselby 2015, 236). Haselby argues that this occurred in the 1850s and can be seen by the shift in the meaning of "sectarian" when the term boomed in printed texts. (ibid., 236)

Infinite is neither an accurate description of contemporary mainstream Evangelist Christianity's propaganda at *Inifinite's* events. The most evident element is the figure of the living prophet, as a sect

guru, against which the Protestants were, because they rejected a figure of central religious authority (Lacorne 2001). The second element is the way racism is depicted. In *Infinite* the racism depicted is closer to what Haselby associates with the plantation owners', where the Black people are completely dehumanised. However, the kind of racism that the New England Tract Society promoted in their literature would accept "inequality, and without apparent limit, while conferring upon the subordinated or subjected a kind of spiritual superiority".(Haselby 2015, 268). The landscape of Columbia depicts arguably the most brutal examples of racism existing in America's History.

Through its multidimensional world, *Infinite* highlights the many facets of American myths and the dangers of having these myths brought to life by just one person.

By being self-reflective both on the players' experience of virtual spaces and the Shining City Upon a Hill, the city of Columbia criticises and subverts the retrotopic use of this myth in political discourses, unlike other Retrotopia like Hope County from *Farcry 5* (Ubisoft 2018) which only reinforces them (Chraibi 2023).

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